Suicide Bereavement:
What Helps and What Hurts?

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Importance:

Suicide is the 3rd leading cause of death among ages 15-25 and the 10th leading cause of all ages[3].There is a commonly held sentiment that Marriage and Family Therapists (MFTs) are only comfortable addressing a narrow range of "problems of living" and not mental disorders[6]. Only 29% of MFTs report feeling comfortable treating severe mental illness[7]. This is problematic because the suicide and even more specifically the bereavement literature commonly calls for family- and systemic-based interventions[8,9,10]. This is even more problematic because of the intergenerational transmission—an foundation of many MFT theories—of depressive and suicidal tendencies[11]. This study's purpose is to develop a systemic understanding of suicide bereavement and what helps and what hurts the healing process.

Methodology:

Grounded theory methodology was used to structure the research process. Participants were recruited through UNLV's training facility and through calls for participants on social media websites (Facebook & Twitter). Each interview was audio recorded, transcribed, and then analyzed through constant comparison. Each member of the analysis team independently open-coded the data and then met to discuss and agree upon common themes. Each participant was invited to further reliability through completing member checks.

Results:

Three broad hurtful and three helpful themes were identified in each interview, with sub-themes that were shared by at least three participants. It is also specifically worth noting that suicidal ideation was only spoken about as a helpful process by the participants.

Sample Results:

Isolation	It always felt like I wasn't allowed to be part of the grieving of my brother. I wasn't allowed to move or touch his things. I wasn't asked about him. I wanted to go look for him when he was missing but my parents continually made excuses to not allow me. My siblings and parents attended family counseling sessions but I stayed home 'because I was so young'. They didn't let me read his suicide note. I didn't even know he had written one until 20 years after his death. I remember when I was young I would sometimes wake up in the night crying because I missed him and I would take one of his pictures into my room. It always got taken out while I was in school and put back where it was before. It always felt like they were basically saying my pain wasn't real because I was a kid
Responsibility	While deployed, he called one day and asked me how I would feel if someday I learned he had been killed in a terrible car accident. He was experiencing severe emotional pain at this point, and my comment was I would be devastated. Horribly sad. But also relieved that he would be out of emotion pain for which there was no known resolution. Now, after thought this makes me feel this was his way of asking my approval to die, and I had unknowing of his suicidal thoughts, granted it. Another reoccurring and haunting thought I have is circumstances around his birth. I was pregnant out of wedlock, and many people close to me suggested adoption. The birth father's first choice was abortion. No way was abortion an option I would consider, but I have often wondered if I would have placed my first born child for adoption, would his life been happier. Would he not be wounded with the feelings of rejection and abandonment that came with the divorce when he was six years old, and the 19 years of abandonment that followed
Social support	My obstetrician cancelled all his patients and came to the services. That type of response [was helpful]…There was a man that he had [worked for] that came to the funeral. He was not a church-going man and had a long ponytail, but out of respect for my son he came to the services inside of a church and cut off his pony tail because he wanted to show respect to my son's belief. Those types of actions, to me, portrayed the respect and love people saw in him
Making meaning	The first bit of comfort I ever felt about his death was when I learned of the depression he had been experiencing and the deep feelings of abandonment and unworthiness that was constant for him. It was comforting because I finally was able to think that his pain finally ended.
Continuing bonds	I have a windbreaker in my closet that he rode when he biked. I used to wear it but it's too small for me now. My wife has tried to convince me to get rid of it and I've tried. I just can't let go of it. Just like I have an old school Sony Walkman that he gave me that doesn't work anymore. That one is really difficult to let go because he gave it to me the last time I saw him

Email huntx271@umn.edu for more information or a copy of the poster. For updates on the research and to hear about the updates in the research check out: z.umn.edu/suicidebereavement

Hurtful Themes:

Isolation
- Feeling excluded
- Not being willing to talk about it
- Lack of connection

Responsibility
- Feeling responsible for death
- Feeling pressure to replace

Lack of coping skills
- Addiction
- Suicidal ideation

Helpful Themes:

Social support
- Funeral
  - Respect
  - Feeling included
- Love and attachment
- Communication and talking about suicide
- Connection with other survivors

Making meaning
- Letting it be good
- Making it have meaning

Continuing bonds
- Keeping memory alive through artifacts
- Spiritual belief and continuation of existence
- Previous grief and loss
- Suicidal ideation

Implications:

There are profound issues of internalized shame and attachment-related issues of the internal working model that have potential to significantly impact many, if not all, future relationships in some suicide survivors. Half of the participants report high attachment insecurity and anxiety. Suicidal ideation functions as a double-bind both acting as a connection while preventing "getting over it."